AN ARGUMENT FROM THE CHURCH'S OWN WORDS

The Case for Sedevacantism: An Argument from the Church's Own Words

Every quotation is given with its source so it can be checked. Where the other side has a reply, the reply is stated.

Before the Council After the Council The contradiction

Summary

This paper argues that the men who have claimed the papacy since the Second Vatican Council (1962–1965) do not hold the authority of the Roman Pontiff, and that the Apostolic See is therefore vacant (*sede vacante*).

It uses no private revelation and no new theology. It argues from texts that every Catholic accepts: popes, councils, the Code of Canon Law and the standard theology manuals. Every quotation is given with its source so that it can be checked. Where the other side has a reply, the reply is stated.

The argument has four steps:

1. **The Church cannot teach error, impose harmful universal laws, or give her children invalid or doubtful sacraments.** This follows from her divine constitution.
2. **The post-conciliar authorities have done these things.** Their official teaching and law contradict what the Church taught and legislated before the Council, often word for word. The paper sets out more than twenty such contradictions side by side.
3. **One who holds the Church's authority cannot do these things.** So the authority that did them is not the authority of the Church.
4. **The same Catholic theology explains how this is possible.** A public heretic is not a member of the Church and cannot be her head, and the Church can survive a long vacancy of the Holy See.

The strongest objection, that the Church must remain visible with a hierarchy, is answered honestly in section 8, including the question that remains open.

1. What is being claimed, and what is not

What is claimed. The Catholic Church still exists, with her faith, her sacraments and her divine constitution. The Holy See is vacant because the claimants since the Council have publicly professed and imposed doctrines that the Church condemned, and a public heretic cannot hold office in the Church.

What is not claimed.

- It is not a denial of the papacy. The argument depends on the papacy: it is precisely because the pope's teaching and laws are protected by God that the conciliar teaching and laws cannot come from a pope.
- It is not private judgment. The contradictions are between public, official documents. Comparing two published texts is not a private opinion about anyone's soul.
- It is not a claim to have authority to depose anyone. Catholic canon law teaches that public defection from the faith empties an office *of itself*, "without any declaration" (canon 188 §4, below).
- It is not a claim that every Catholic who attends the new rites is personally guilty. Ignorance and good faith are real. The argument concerns the authority that promulgated the changes.

2. Three principles every Catholic accepts

Principle 1: The Church cannot give error or evil

> **VATICAN I**, *Pastor Aeternus* ch. 4 (1870; EWTN translation):
> "This gift of truth and never-failing faith was therefore divinely conferred on Peter and his successors in this See … so that … the whole Church is preserved in unity, and, resting on its foundation, can stand firm against the gates of hell."

> **PIUS XII**, *Mystici Corporis* §66 (1943):
> "the loving Mother is spotless in the Sacraments … in the faith which she has always preserved inviolate; in her sacred laws imposed on all"

> **COUNCIL OF TRENT**, Session 22, canon 7:
> "If any one saith, that the ceremonies, vestments, and outward signs, which the Catholic Church makes use of in the celebration of masses, are incentives to impiety, rather than offices of piety; let him be anathema."

The Church's faith, her universal laws and her rites are protected. A Catholic cannot hold that the Church's authority imposed on the whole Church a doctrine she had condemned, a law contrary to faith, or a rite that endangers the sacraments.

Principle 2: The meaning of dogma never changes

> **VATICAN I**, *Dei Filius* ch. 4 (1870):
> "that meaning of the sacred dogmas is ever to be maintained which has once been declared by holy mother church, and there must never be any abandonment of this sense under the pretext or in the name of a more profound understanding."

> **OATH AGAINST MODERNISM** (Pius X, 1910), sworn by every priest until 1967:
> "I entirely reject the heretical misrepresentation that dogmas evolve and change from one meaning to another different from the one which the Church held previously."

Doctrine can be understood more deeply, but only "in the same dogma, the same sense, the same meaning" (*eodem sensu*, *Dei Filius*). A later teaching that says the opposite of an earlier one is not development.

Principle 3: A public heretic is not a member of the Church and cannot hold office in her

> **PIUS XII**, *Mystici Corporis* §22:
> "Actually only those are to be included as members of the Church who have been baptized and profess the true faith … It follows that those who are divided in faith or government cannot be living in the unity of such a Body"

> **CODE OF CANON LAW** (1917), canon 188 §4:
> "quaelibet officia vacant ipso facto et sine ulla declaratione, si clericus: … 4º A fide catholica publice defecerit"
> (All offices become vacant by the fact itself and without any declaration if a cleric … has publicly defected from the Catholic faith.)

> **MGR G. VAN NOORT**, *Christ's Church*, p. 241:
> "if public material heretics remained members of the Church, the visibility and unity of Christ's Church would perish."

This is the view defended by St Robert Bellarmine (*De Romano Pontifice* II.30): one who is not a member of the Church cannot be her head.

Put together: if official, universal teaching and law since the Council contradict the Church's teaching and law, then either the Church has failed, which is impossible (Principle 1), or the authority that imposed them was not the Church's authority (Principle 3). The rest of this paper shows the contradictions.

3. Religious liberty

The Church taught that the State must profess the true religion, that error has no rights, and that non-Catholic worship may at most be *tolerated* for a grave reason. Vatican II declared a natural right, grounded in revelation, to practise any religion in public.

3.1 Liberty of worship as a personal right written into civil law

Before · Pius IX, *Quanta Cura* §3 (1864), condemning the opinion that Gregory XVI had called *deliramentum* ("insanity"):
"liberty of conscience and worship is each man's personal right, which ought to be legally proclaimed and asserted in every rightly constituted society"

After · Vatican II, *Dignitatis Humanae* §2 (1965):
"This right of the human person to religious freedom is to be recognized in the constitutional law whereby society is governed and thus it is to become a civil right."

The contradiction: the condemned proposition and the conciliar one have the same structure: a personal right to religious freedom which civil law must proclaim. Pius IX attached his full authority to the condemnation: "by our Apostolic authority, we reprobate, proscribe, and condemn all the singular and evil opinions and doctrines severally mentioned in this letter" (§6).

> **Objection:** *Dignitatis Humanae* means only freedom from coercion "within due limits", not the unlimited liberty Pius IX condemned.

> **Answer:** Pius IX did not only condemn unlimited liberty. In the same paragraph (3.6 below) he condemned the view that the State may restrain false religion *only* as far as public peace requires, which is exactly the limit the Council adopted.

3.2 A right given by nature

BEFORE · Leo XIII, *Libertas* §42 (1888):
"it is quite unlawful to demand, to defend, or to grant unconditional freedom of thought, of speech, or writing, or of worship, as if these were so many rights given by nature to man."

AFTER · *Dignitatis Humanae* §2:
"Therefore the right to religious freedom has its foundation not in the subjective disposition of the person, but in his very nature."

The contradiction: Leo XIII denies that freedom of worship is a right given by nature. The Council grounds it in human nature itself, and adds that this dignity is known "through the revealed word of God and by reason itself" (§2).

3.3 Rights for those in error

BEFORE · Pius XII, *Ci Riesce* §V (1953):
"that which does not correspond to truth or to the norm of morality objectively has no right to exist, to be spread or to be activated."
Leo XIII, *Libertas* §34: "it is contrary to reason that error and truth should have equal rights."

AFTER · *Dignitatis Humanae* §2:
"the right to this immunity continues to exist even in those who do not live up to their obligation of seeking the truth and adhering to it and the exercise of this right is not to be impeded, provided that just public order be observed."

The contradiction: error had "no right … to be spread". Now those who do not seek or hold the truth have a right whose public exercise "is not to be impeded".

> **Objection:** the right belongs to the person, not to the error.

> **Answer:** the right in question is the right *to act publicly* on one's religion, that is, to spread and practise it. Pius XII denied that very thing to error: no right "to be spread or to be activated".

3.4 Public worship of non-Catholic religions

BEFORE · *Syllabus of Errors*, proposition 78 (condemned, 1864):
"Hence it has been wisely decided by law, in some Catholic countries, that persons coming to reside therein shall enjoy the public exercise of their own peculiar worship."

AFTER · *Dignitatis Humanae* §4:
"Provided the just demands of public order are observed, religious communities rightfully claim freedom in order that they may govern themselves according to their own norms, honor the Supreme Being in public worship…"

The contradiction: the Syllabus condemns praising laws that grant non-Catholics public worship in Catholic countries. The Council declares that public worship a right. Michael Davies, a defender of the traditional Mass who did not hold the sedevacantist position, wrote: "One instance in which it appears impossible to deny the existence of a formal contradiction is that of Proposition 78."

3.5 The Catholic State

BEFORE · *Syllabus*, proposition 77 (condemned):
"In the present day it is no longer expedient that the Catholic religion should be held as the only religion of the State, to the exclusion of all other forms of worship."

AFTER · *Dignitatis Humanae* §6:
"If, in view of peculiar circumstances obtaining among peoples, special civil recognition is given to one religious community in the constitutional order of society, it is at the same time imperative that the right of all citizens and religious communities to religious freedom should be recognized and made effective in practice."

The contradiction: the Catholic State, to the exclusion of other forms of worship, was the norm, and it was condemned to say otherwise. The Council makes it an exception for "peculiar circumstances", and even then requires religious freedom for all. This was applied at once: Spain's organic law of 10 January 1967 rewrote Article 6 of its Charter, citing *Dignitatis Humanae* §2.

3.6 The State's duty to restrain false religion

> **BEFORE** · *Quanta Cura* §3, condemning the view that the best society is one
> "in which no duty is recognized, as attached to the civil power, of restraining by enacted penalties, offenders against the Catholic religion, except so far as public peace may require."

> **AFTER** · *Dignitatis Humanae* §3:
> "it would clearly transgress the limits set to its power, were it to presume to command or inhibit acts that are religious."
> §7: "These matters constitute the basic component of the common welfare: they are what is meant by public order."

> **The contradiction:** Pius IX condemned denying that the State has a duty to restrain offenders against the Catholic religion beyond what public peace requires. The Council says the State exceeds its power if it inhibits religious acts at all, apart from public order.

> **Objection:** the Council's "public order" includes public morality and the rights of others, so it is broader than Pius IX's "public peace".

> **Answer:** both are limits drawn from the needs of civil society, not from the truth of religion. That is exactly what Pius IX condemned: a State that recognizes no duty toward the true religion as such.

What the Council's defenders concede. Benedict XVI, addressing the Roman Curia (22 December 2005), said of these questions: "a discontinuity had been revealed", and the Council "has reviewed or even corrected certain historical decisions". The drafter of *Dignitatis Humanae*, Fr John Courtney Murray SJ, described it as "discarding an older theory of civil tolerance in favor of a new doctrine of religious freedom", a theory which "can hardly be regarded as permanent Catholic doctrine".

4. Ecumenism and the one true Church

The Church taught that she alone is the Church of Christ, that those divided from her in faith are not her members, and that unity comes only by return to her. After the Council, the Church of Christ is said to be present in other communities, which are means of salvation, and common worship is encouraged.

4.1 The Church of Christ *is* the Catholic Church

BEFORE · Pius XII, *Humani Generis* §27 (1950), censuring those who reject:
"the doctrine … which teaches that the Mystical Body of Christ and the Roman Catholic Church are one and the same thing." *Mystici Corporis* §13 (1943): "this true Church of Jesus Christ - which is the One, Holy, Catholic, Apostolic and Roman Church"

AFTER · Vatican II, *Lumen Gentium* §8 (1964):
"This Church constituted and organized in the world as a society, subsists in the Catholic Church … although many elements of sanctification and of truth are found outside of its visible structure."
John Paul II, *Ut Unum Sint* §11 (1995): "To the extent that these elements are found in other Christian Communities, the one Church of Christ is effectively present in them."

The contradiction: identity ("one and the same thing") becomes "subsists in", and the Church of Christ is said to be "effectively present" in non-Catholic communities.

> **Objection:** Rome's doctrinal office (2007) declared that "subsists in" "indicates the full identity of the Church of Christ with the Catholic Church".

> **Answer:** a declaration that there is no contradiction does not remove the words. John Paul II's "effectively present in them" is not identity. Cardinal Ratzinger himself wrote in 2000 that "this difference between *subsistit* and *est* cannot be fully resolved from the logical viewpoint."

4.2 Who are members of the Body

BEFORE · *Mystici Corporis* §22:
"Actually only those are to be included as members of the Church who have been baptized and profess the true faith … It follows that those who are divided in faith or government cannot be living in the unity of such a Body"

AFTER · *Unitatis Redintegratio* §3 (1964):
"all who have been justified by faith in Baptism are members of Christ's body, and have a right to be called Christian."

The contradiction: those "divided in faith" are not members. Now all the validly baptized, including Protestants, are "members of Christ's body".

4.3 Separated communities and salvation

BEFORE · Pius XI, *Mortalium Animos* §10 (1928):
"whosoever therefore is not united with the body is no member of it, neither is he in communion with Christ its head."

AFTER · *Unitatis Redintegratio* §3:
"the separated Churches and Communities as such … have been by no means deprived of significance and importance in the mystery of salvation. For the Spirit of Christ has not refrained from using them as means of salvation"

The contradiction: outside the Body there is no communion with Christ the Head. Now the separated communities *as such* are means of salvation.

4.4 Joining non-Catholics in worship

BEFORE · *Mortalium Animos* §8:
"the Apostolic See cannot on any terms take part in their assemblies, nor is it anyway lawful for Catholics either to support or to work for such enterprises"
Code of Canon Law (1917), canon 1258 §1: "Haud licitum est fidelibus quovis modo active assistere seu partem habere in sacris acatholicorum." (It is not lawful for the faithful *in any way* to assist actively at, or take part in, non-Catholic worship.)

AFTER · *Unitatis Redintegratio* §8:
"it is allowable, indeed desirable that Catholics should join in prayer with their separated brethren"
§15: "some worship in common (communicatio in sacris), given suitable circumstances and the approval of Church authority, is not only possible but to be encouraged."

The contradiction: forbidden "in any way" becomes "desirable" and "to be encouraged". Under the old Code, one who took part in non-Catholic worship was "suspect of heresy" (canon 2316).

> **Objection:** this is discipline, and the Church may change her discipline.

> **Answer:** the prohibition protects a truth of faith: that worship professes the faith of those who join in it. Even Fr Brian Harrison, who defends the Council, calls the change "practically a U-turn". And a universal law that leads Catholics into practices the Church condemned as abandoning revealed religion (*Mortalium Animos* §2) is exactly what Principle 1 rules out.

4.5 Other religions

BEFORE · *Mortalium Animos* §2:
"that false opinion which considers all religions to be more or less good and praiseworthy … one who supports those who hold these theories and attempt to realize them, is altogether abandoning the divinely revealed religion."

AFTER · *Nostra Aetate* §2 (1965):
"The Catholic Church rejects nothing that is true and holy in these religions. She regards with sincere reverence those ways of conduct and of life, those precepts and teachings…"
John Paul II, General Audience, 9 September 1998 §2: "The various religions arose precisely from this primordial human openness to God … We experienced an eloquent manifestation of this truth at the World Day of Prayer for Peace on 27 October 1986 in Assisi."

The contradiction: Pius XI condemns supporting those who hold that all religions are "more or less good". After the Council the false religions are regarded "with sincere reverence", are said to have arisen from an openness to God that the same audience calls "inspired by the Holy Spirit", and are gathered to pray at Assisi.

5. At the altar: Communion as the sign of unity in faith

The Eucharist is the sacrament of the Church's unity. St Thomas: "the Eucharist is the sacrament of the Church's unity" (*Summa* III q.73 a.2). The Council of Trent: it is "a symbol of that one body whereof He is the head, and to which He would fain have us as members be united by the closest bond of faith" (Session 13, ch. 2). To give Communion is to declare unity in faith. The post-conciliar Church now gives that sign to those who do not share the faith.

5.1 Sacraments for non-Catholics

BEFORE · Code of Canon Law (1917), canon 731 §2:
"Vetitum est Sacramenta Ecclesiae ministrare haereticis aut schismaticis, etiam bona fide errantibus eaque petentibus, nisi prius, erroribus reiectis, Ecclesiae reconciliati fuerint."
(It is forbidden to give the sacraments of the Church to heretics or schismatics, *even those erring in good faith* who ask for them, unless they have first renounced their errors and been reconciled to the Church.)

AFTER · Code of Canon Law (1983), canon 844 §3:
"Catholic ministers administer the sacraments of penance, Eucharist, and anointing of the sick licitly to members of Eastern Churches which do not have full communion with the Catholic Church if they seek such on their own accord and are properly disposed."

The contradiction: no sacraments without renouncing error and being reconciled. Now the Eucharist is given lawfully with neither. This is universal law, binding on the whole Church. Before the Council a schismatic could not even be *named* at the altar: Benedict XIV ruled that bishops are named in the liturgy "provided they are Catholic. But if either or both of them are schismatic or heretic they should by no means be commemorated" (*Ex Quo* §9, 1756). Now he may *receive Communion* there.

5.2 Catholics at the sacraments of non-Catholics

BEFORE · St Thomas Aquinas, *Summa* III q.82 a.9:
"heretics, schismatics, and excommunicates, have been forbidden, by the Church's sentence, to perform the Eucharistic rite. And therefore whoever hears their mass or receives the sacraments from them, commits sin."

AFTER · John Paul II, *Ecclesia de Eucharistia* §46 (2003):
"Conversely, in specific cases and in particular circumstances, Catholics too can request these same sacraments from ministers of Churches in which these sacraments are valid."

The contradiction: receiving the sacraments from schismatics is a sin. Now Catholics may ask schismatic ministers for them.

5.3 The sign of unity set aside

BEFORE · Council of Trent, Session 13, ch. 2:
the Eucharist is "a symbol of that one body whereof He is the head, and to which He would fain have us as members be united by the closest bond of faith, hope, and charity, that we might all speak the same things, and there might be no schisms amongst us."

AFTER · *Unitatis Redintegratio* §8 (Latin):
"Significatio unitatis plerumque vetat communicationem. Gratia procuranda quandoque illam commendat."
(Signifying unity for the most part forbids common worship. The grace to be obtained sometimes recommends it.)

The contradiction: the Eucharist signifies unity in faith. Now the sign may "sometimes" be shared with those who lack that unity. John Paul II himself wrote that "the sacrament of his body and blood does not permit duplicity" (*Ecclesia de Eucharistia* §38) and that the Church's unity "absolutely requires full communion in the bonds of the profession of faith, the sacraments and ecclesiastical governance" (§44), and then allowed the exceptions in §45–46.

The pope's name in the Canon of the Mass

The same principle explains why many traditional priests no longer name the conciliar claimants in the Mass. In the Canon the priest offers the Sacrifice "for Thy holy Catholic Church … together with Thy

servant N. our Pope" (*una cum famulo tuo Papa nostro N.*). Benedict XIV taught that this naming "recognizes him as the head of the Church, the vicar of Christ, and the successor of blessed Peter, and is the profession of a mind and will which firmly espouses Catholic unity" (*Ex Quo*, 1756). Rome still teaches the same: "Every valid celebration of the Eucharist expresses this universal communion with Peter and with the whole Church" (*Communionis Notio* §14, 1992). The Roman Missal's own rubric provides for the case of a vacancy: "Sede autem vacante verba praedicta omittuntur" (when the See is vacant, these words are omitted).

6. The 1968 rite for consecrating bishops

In 1968 Paul VI replaced the essential words of the rite by which bishops are consecrated. Because bishops ordain priests, the validity of this rite affects every sacrament that depends on the priesthood. The claim here is the moderate one: the new rite is at least *positively doubtful*, and the Church forbids relying on a doubtful sacrament.

6.1 The essential words

BEFORE · Pius XII, *Sacramentum Ordinis* §4–5 (1947): the form must be words "quibus univoce significantur effectus sacramentales, — scilicet potestas Ordinis et gratia Spiritus Sancti" (which univocally signify the sacramental effects, namely the power of Order and the grace of the Holy Spirit). The form for bishops:
«Comple in Sacerdote tuo ministerii tui summam, et ornamentis totius glorificationis instructum coelestis unguenti rore sanctifica.»

AFTER · Paul VI, *Pontificalis Romani* (1968), which repeats the same rule and then prescribes:
«Et nunc effunde super hunc Electum eam virtutem, quae a te est, Spiritum principalem, quem dedisti dilecto Filio Tuo Iesu Christo, quem Ipse donavit sanctis Apostolis, qui constituerunt Ecclesiam per singula loca, ut sanctuarium tuum, in gloriam et laudem indeficientem nominis tui.»

The contradiction: the old form names the priesthood (*Sacerdote*) and its fullness (*ministerii tui summam*). The new essential words name neither, yet Paul VI himself applies the rule that they must signify the power of Order *univocally*.

6.2 Invoking the Holy Spirit is not enough

BEFORE · Leo XIII, *Apostolicae Curae* §25 (1896), judging the Anglican rite:
"'Receive the Holy Ghost,' certainly do not in the least definitely express the sacred Order of Priesthood (sacerdotium) or its grace and power"

AFTER · *Pontificalis Romani* (1968), the essential petition:
"effunde super hunc Electum eam virtutem, quae a te est, Spiritum principalem" (pour out upon this elect the power that is from you, the governing Spirit)

The contradiction: Leo XIII ruled that a bare invocation of the Spirit does not determine which Order is conferred. The core of the new form is an invocation of the "governing Spirit", a phrase which, as Fr Anthony Cekada documented, is also used of kings, abbots and other leaders.

> **Objection:** the meaning is fixed by the surrounding prayer, and the prayer comes from ancient Eastern rites (Fr Pierre-Marie OP, for the Society of St Pius X).

> **Answer:** the defender himself concedes that the essential part is "insufficiently determined" on its own, which is the opposite of univocal. The Eastern prayers cited are, in the Maronite and Syrian rites, prayers for installing a patriarch who is usually already a bishop, not the sacramental form.

Why doubt is enough. In 1679 the Holy Office condemned this proposition: "It is not illicit in conferring sacraments to follow a probable opinion regarding the value of the sacrament, the safer opinion being abandoned" (Denzinger 1151). In sacraments the safer course is obligatory. Even the Society of St Pius X, which holds the rite valid, conditionally re-ordains priests from the conciliar Church as a precaution, and its own writer calls the question "even more delicate … The difficulty lies in the complete change of the wording of the form" (Fr Peter Scott).

7. A different religion, not a reformed one

How a religion is identified

St Robert Bellarmine's classic definition: the Church is "the assembly of men, bound together by the profession of the same Christian faith, and by the communion of the same sacraments, under the rule of legitimate pastors, and in particular of the one Vicar of Christ on earth, the Roman Pontiff" (*De Ecclesia Militante* III.2). A religion is identified by **what it professes, how it worships, and whom it obeys**.

Worship is itself a profession of faith. Pius XII: "The worship she offers to God … is a continuous profession of Catholic faith … The entire liturgy, therefore, has the Catholic faith for its content, inasmuch as it bears public witness to the faith of the Church" (*Mediator Dei* §47). That is why Leo XIII judged the Anglican reform a change of religion and not merely of ceremony: "Being fully cognisant of the necessary connection between faith and worship, between 'the law of believing and the law of praying', under a pretext of returning to the primitive form, they corrupted the Liturgical Order in many ways to suit the errors of the reformers" (*Apostolicae Curae* §30).

Sections 3–6 showed the change in what is professed. The following show the change in the profession itself and in worship.

7.1 The meaning of dogma

> **BEFORE** · Vatican I, *Dei Filius* ch. 4 (1870):
> "that meaning of the sacred dogmas is ever to be maintained which has once been declared by holy mother church, and there must never be any abandonment of this sense under the pretext or in the name of a more profound understanding."

> **AFTER** · John Paul II, *Ecclesia Dei* §4 (1988), on Archbishop Lefebvre:
> "an incomplete and contradictory notion of Tradition. Incomplete, because it does not take sufficiently into account the living character of Tradition"
> Cardinal Arthur Roche, Prefect for Divine Worship, BBC Radio 4, 19 March 2023, explaining the restriction of the old Mass: "You know the theology of the Church has changed." (broadcast; as transcribed by Dr Joseph Shaw)

The contradiction: the fixed meaning that every priest swore to uphold is set against a "living" Tradition, invoked to condemn the bishop who held to the fixed meaning. A Roman prefect says outright that the theology has changed.

7.2 The sworn profession of faith

BEFORE · Oath against Modernism (1910):
"the absolute and immutable truth preached by the apostles from the beginning may never be believed to be different, may never be understood in any other way."

AFTER · Congregation for the Doctrine of the Faith, 17 July 1967, the document's own title:
"Formula to adopt from now on in cases in which the Profession of Faith is prescribed by law in substitution of the Tridentine formula and the oath against modernism"

The contradiction: two years after the Council, the legally required profession of faith was replaced and the oath against the evolution of dogma was dropped.

7.3 Condemning the modern errors

BEFORE · Pius X, *Pascendi* §39 (1907):
modernism is "the synthesis of all heresies … the destruction not of the Catholic religion alone but of all religion." *Quanta Cura* §6 (1864): "by our Apostolic authority, we reprobate, proscribe, and condemn all the singular and evil opinions and doctrines severally mentioned in this letter"

AFTER · Paul VI, closing address of Vatican II, 7 December 1965:
"The religion of the God who became man has met the religion (for such it is) of man who makes himself God. And what happened? Was there a clash, a battle, a condemnation? There could have been, but there was none."
Official Latin: "nam nos etiam, immo nos prae ceteris, hominis sumus cultores" (for we too, indeed we more than any others, are devotees of man).

The contradiction: the popes met the religion of man with solemn condemnation. The Council's pope says there was none, and calls the Church its foremost devotees.

> **Objection:** in the same address Paul VI turns this humanism toward God: "our Christianity becomes centered on God".

> **Answer:** the same address also says "a knowledge of man is a prerequisite for a knowledge of God", which reverses the order of the Catholic religion rather than correcting humanism.

7.4 Changing the received rites

BEFORE · Council of Trent, Session 7, canon 13:
"If any one saith, that the received and approved rites of the Catholic Church, wont to be used in the solemn administration of the sacraments, may be contemned, or without sin be omitted at pleasure by the ministers, or be changed, by every pastor of the churches, into other new ones; let him be anathema."
Pius XII, *Sacramentum Ordinis* §1: "Ecclesiae nulla competat potestas in substantiam Sacramentorum" (the Church has no power over the substance of the sacraments).

AFTER · Paul VI, *Divinae Consortium Naturae* (1971), on Confirmation:
"Nos in hac recognitione includi voluimus etiam ea, quae ad ipsam essentiam ritus confirmande [sic] pertinent" (in this revision We wished to include also the things that pertain to the very essence of the rite) *Sacram Unctionem Infirmorum* (1972), on Extreme Unction: "We thought fit to modify the sacramental formula"

The contradiction: between 1968 and 1972 every sacramental rite was rewritten, including what Paul VI himself calls the "very essence" of the rite.

7.5 What the Mass is

BEFORE · Council of Trent, Session 22, canons 1 and 3:
"If any one saith, that in the mass a true and proper sacrifice is not offered to God … let him be anathema." "If any one saith, that the sacrifice of the mass is only a sacrifice of praise and of thanksgiving; or, that it is a bare commemoration of the sacrifice consummated on the cross, but not a propitiatory sacrifice … let him be anathema."

AFTER · General Instruction of the Roman Missal (1969), article 7:
"Cena dominica sive Missa est sacra synaxis seu congregatio populi Dei in unum convenientis, sacerdote praeside, ad memoriale Domini celebrandum." (The Lord's Supper or Mass is the sacred meeting or assembly of the People of God gathered together, the priest presiding, to celebrate the memorial of the Lord.)

The contradiction: Trent defines a true and propitiatory sacrifice offered by the priest. The new Missal defined an assembly and a memorial, with no sacrifice and no priest acting in the person of Christ. Rome rewrote the definition in 1970, but the rite it described was not changed. Cardinals Ottaviani and Bacci had written to Paul VI that the new rite "represents, both as a whole and in its details, a striking departure from the Catholic theology of the Mass as it was formulated in Session XXII of the Council of Trent."

Paul VI himself admitted the scale of the change. The old Mass, he said, had been regarded "come espressione tradizionale e intangibile del nostro culto religioso, dell'autenticità della nostra fede" (as the traditional and untouchable expression of our worship, of the authenticity of our faith), and he called the new rite "questa grave mutazione" (this grave change) (General Audiences, 19 and 26 November 1969).

7.6 Rome against itself

BENEDICT XVI · *Summorum Pontificum* art. 1 and letter to the bishops (2007):
"These two expressions of the Church's lex orandi will in no way lead to a division in the Church's lex credendi … for they are two usages of the one Roman rite." "What earlier generations held as sacred, remains sacred and great for us too, and it cannot be all of a sudden entirely forbidden or even considered harmful."

FRANCIS · *Traditionis Custodes* art. 1 (2021):
"The liturgical books promulgated by Saint Paul VI and Saint John Paul II, in conformity with the decrees of Vatican Council II, are the unique expression of the lex orandi of the Roman Rite."

The contradiction: "two usages of the one Roman rite" that "cannot be … forbidden" becomes one "unique expression". Francis gave the reason himself: "The problematic is primarily ecclesiological" (*Desiderio Desideravi* §31). If the old rite and the new expressed the same faith, there would be no ecclesiological problem.

What this adds up to

The post-conciliar body has a different profession (the oath abolished, "living Tradition", the doctrines of sections 3–4), a different worship (rites rewritten in their essence, a Mass newly defined), and pastors whose authority is in question (section 6 and Principle 3). By Bellarmine's three bonds, it is not the same religion. Archbishop Lefebvre, who never held the sedevacantist position, said the same in 1976: "This Conciliar Church is a schismatic Church, because it breaks with the Catholic Church of all time. It has its new dogmas, its new priesthood, its new institutions, its new worship."

8. Objections and answers

"Who are you to judge the pope?"

No one here claims to judge or depose a pope. The question is whether a man who publicly professes what the Church condemns *is* the pope. Canon law answers that public defection from the faith empties an office "by the fact itself and without any declaration" (canon 188 §4). Comparing published documents is not private judgment: the texts are public and can be read by anyone.

"The texts can be read in continuity. These are only changes of discipline or emphasis."

Those who defend the Council themselves admit the discontinuity. Benedict XVI: "a discontinuity had been revealed". Fr Brian Harrison on ecumenism: "practically a U-turn". Michael Davies on religious liberty: "impossible to deny the existence of a formal contradiction". Cardinal Ratzinger on "subsists in": "cannot be fully resolved from the logical viewpoint". And the reading-in-continuity was abandoned by Rome itself in 2021, when the rite Benedict XVI called "sacred and great" was declared no longer an expression of the Church's law of prayer.

"If the Church has been without a pope for sixty years, she is no longer visible. Christ promised she would last."

This is the strongest objection. Archbishop Lefebvre put it this way (8 November 1979): "The visibility of the Church is too necessary to its existence for it to be possible that God would allow that visibility to disappear for decades."

The Church must be visible. Leo XIII: "those who arbitrarily conjure up and picture to themselves a hidden and invisible Church are in grievous and pernicious error" (*Satis Cognitum* §3). The answer cannot be an invisible Church.

But visibility means a public society bound by faith, sacraments and government, not numbers or recognition. The *Catholic Encyclopedia* ("The Church", 1908): "The material visibility of the Church involves no more than that it must ever be a public, not a private profession"; and "the incapacity to see is due, not to the want of visibility in the Church, but to the blindness of the individual." The Church

remains visible in the clergy and faithful who publicly keep the faith and the sacraments. Archbishop Lefebvre said this himself in 1988: "it is we who bear the marks of the visible Church."

This has happened before in part. In the Arian crisis, St Jerome wrote: "The whole world groaned, and was astonished to find itself Arian" (*Dialogue against the Luciferians* §19). St Basil described the faithful who "shun the churches as schools of impiety; and lift their hands in the deserts with sighs and tears to their Lord in heaven" (*Letter* 92). St Gregory Nazianzen: "These men have the houses, but we the Dweller in the house; they the Temples, we the God" (*Oration* 33).

A long vacancy of the Holy See is not excluded. The papacy is perpetual as an office, not as an unbroken occupancy:

- Dorsch, *De Ecclesia Christi* (1928): the Church may remain without her head "per aliquod tempus vel etiam per plures annos" (for some time or even for several years), "manet enim ejus forma monarchica" (for her monarchical form remains).
- Berry, *The Church of Christ* (1927), pp. 397–398: "the Apostolic succession cannot fail in the Apostolic See so long as the Church herself continues to exist, for although the see be vacant for many years, the Church always retains the right to elect a legitimate successor."
- O'Reilly SJ, *The Relations of the Church to Society* (1892), p. 283, on the Western Schism: "not that an interregnum covering the whole period would have been impossible or inconsistent with the promises of Christ, for this is by no means manifest".
- History: the See was vacant about four years (304–308) and almost three years (1268–1271), and for nearly forty years (1378–1417) "the faithful faced the anxious problem: where is the true pope? The saints themselves were divided" (*Catholic Encyclopedia*, "Western Schism").

What remains open. The theologians who allow a long vacancy assume that diocesan bishops with ordinary jurisdiction remain in place during it. Where such bishops are today, and how a future pope will be elected, are real questions that sedevacantist theologians answer in different ways. This paper does not pretend they are settled. But every alternative faces a greater difficulty (see the last objection below), and Catholic theology already holds that, when the Church is without a certain head, "the Church … has the right and the power to provide for herself" (O'Reilly, p. 287).

"The whole Church accepted these popes, and universal acceptance is an infallible sign of a legitimate pope."

The principle is from Cardinal Billot. But in the same passage Billot also writes: "Equidem permittere potest Deus ut aliquando vacatio sedis diutius protrahatur" (God can indeed permit that at times the vacancy of the See be prolonged for a long time) (*De Ecclesia Christi*, 1909, pp. 620–621).

St Alphonsus, usually quoted for the same principle, continues in the very next sentence: "Ma se per qualche tempo non fosse stato veramente accettato universalmente dalla Chiesa, in tal caso per quel tempo sarebbe vacata la Sede Pontificia" (but if for some time he had not been truly accepted

universally by the Church, for that time the Pontifical See would have been vacant) (*Verità della Fede*, 1767, III.8 n. 9).

Acceptance heals defects in the *election*, such as fraud or irregularity, which are St Alphonsus's own examples. It cannot make a man a member of the Church who has publicly left her faith, because divine law, not the electors, sets that condition. And the acceptance of the conciliar popes has been contested since 1969, when Cardinals Ottaviani and Bacci protested the new Mass.

"Why not simply recognize the pope and resist his errors, as the Society of St Pius X does?"

Because that position meets the same difficulty in a worse form. If the recognized pope and bishops really are the Church's authority, then the Church's authority has given the whole Church error in doctrine, harmful universal law and doubtful sacraments, which Principle 1 says cannot happen. Fr Anthony Cekada put it as a choice between three conclusions: either the new teachings and rites are Catholic, or the authority of the Church has defected, or they are not Catholic and their authors are not the Church's authority. Only the third keeps the Church indefectible. Archbishop Lefebvre himself wrote in 1984: "One has had to live from 1960 to the present moment to discover that Popes can lead the Church to her ruin" (quoted in Tissier de Mallerais, *Marcel Lefebvre: The Biography*, p. 534). Catholic doctrine says popes cannot do that.

The jurisdiction question also applies equally to the Society: its bishops were consecrated against the express will of the man it recognizes as pope.

"Sedevacantists cannot even agree among themselves."

They agree on the conclusion argued here: the conciliar teaching contradicts the Church's teaching, so its authors do not hold the Church's authority. They disagree on secondary questions such as how a future pope will be elected. Disagreement about what follows from a conclusion is not evidence against the conclusion.

9. Conclusion

The Church cannot give her children error, harmful laws or doubtful sacraments. Since the Council, the authorities in Rome have done all three, in official and universal acts, against the express teaching and law of the popes before them. Their own defenders admit the discontinuity. The Church cannot have failed. Therefore those authorities do not possess the Church's authority, and the Holy See is vacant.

This conclusion does not abandon the papacy; it is the only one that keeps intact what the popes taught about the papacy. It leaves a hard question about how the Church's hierarchy will be restored. That question is real, but it is a question about the future. The alternative, that the Church herself has taught error, would be a contradiction of the faith.

> "But yet the Son of man, when he cometh, shall he find, think you, faith on earth?" (Luke 18:8, Douay-Rheims)

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